When I expressed my doubts about the feasibility of mounting an offensive in that terrain, Bijji assured me that, according to Thapar, both 7 Brigade and 4 Division had produced workable plans for the attack; it was only Umrao who (he had been told) was being obstructionist.'

Palit then goes on to say: 'I could see that Bijji was greatly pleased with himself and I could imagine why… Here was his chance to make up for the past, to fill in the blanks in his credentials and to give the lie to his detractors. There would be no holding him back.'

Ever since the Chinese appeared at Dhola on 8 September, the DMO had repeatedly lamented the fact that Kaul was missing from the scene. Once he took over the newly created IV Corps, there was an infusion of optimism that ignored reality. Even though fully aware of Kaul's vain and pompous streak, Palit and many others who interacted with him held Kaul's analytical abilities in high esteem, perhaps next only to that of General Thorat.

Yet, on the way to the airport, Palit failed to tell Kaul, who until then was his direct boss, that according to the Intelligence Bureau chief, he would be facing at least two Chinese regiments. Until then (especially since Kaul was basing his optimism on the Dalvi-Prasad appreciation), the assumption was that on the Thagla Ridge and forward slopes there was just the one company of the PLA (equivalent to an Indian infantry battalion). This vital piece of information being held back at this critical juncture must rate as one of the most serious omissions of the war, bordering perhaps on criminal negligence.

The moment Kaul landed at Tezpur, there were many subtle and some not so subtle messages being given to the rank and file of the Indian Army. The Eastern Army Commander, Bogey Sen, received the new IV Corps Commander at the airfield, which in itself was an unprecedented step. This clearly signalled that Bogey Sen and Eastern Command would fade into the background as the only recognized chain of command would now be Kaul-Menon-Nehru. The sidelining of Umrao Singh was an equally clear message—anyone who had the gumption to protest would be unceremoniously shown the door. In the week that would follow, along with Bogey Sen, even the COAS, Pran Thapar, would fade away from the decision-making process.

While Kaul was in Tezpur, locked in conference with Bogey Sen and Umrao Singh, Niranjan Prasad landed at Lumpu, this time by helicopter.